

CLAUDE.md Explained

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REFERENCE VIDEOS

- How to Write a Good CLAUDE.md File (<https://www.builder.io/blog/claude-md-guide>) -- Builder.io -- Read for the distinction between what belongs in CLAUDE.md vs what does not: the less-is-more principle
- CLAUDE CODE FULL COURSE 4 HOURS: Build & Sell (2026) (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QoQBzR1NIql>) -- Nick Saraev -- Watch the CLAUDE.md section: how Nick writes one from scratch and what he includes vs leaves out
- Using CLAUDE.MD files: Customizing Claude Code for your codebase (<https://claude.com/blog/using-claude-md-files>) -- Anthropic -- The official guide: use as ground truth on what Anthropic intends the file to do

THE ONE THING

CLAUDE.md is a persistent memory file -- it tells Claude how your project works so you never have to explain it again, and it makes every session smarter from the first line.

HOOK

Every Claude Code session starts with Claude knowing nothing about your project -- unless you have a CLAUDE.md file. Here is what it does and how to write one that actually works.

TARGET VIEWER

Someone using Claude Code regularly who re-explains the same project conventions every session, or whose Claude keeps making decisions that do not match their preferences.

PAYOFF

After watching, the viewer knows exactly what goes in a CLAUDE.md, what stays out, and can write one for their current project that immediately reduces re-explanation and improves Claude decision quality.

BEAT STRUCTURE

Beat -- Claude Forgets Everything

Point: Every Claude Code session starts from scratch -- Claude has no memory of your last session, your preferences, or your conventions unless you write them down in CLAUDE.md.

Visual: Two terminal sessions: session 1 (user re-explains context, Claude makes wrong assumption); session 2 with CLAUDE.md (Claude navigates correctly from first command)

Target words: ~110w

Beat -- What CLAUDE.md Is

Point: CLAUDE.md is a markdown file in your project root that Claude Code reads automatically at session start. It becomes part of Claude's context before you type a single word.

Visual: File explorer: CLAUDE.md in project root. Open it to show contents. Split with terminal showing Claude referencing it -- "I can see from your CLAUDE.md that..."

Target words: ~160w

Beat -- What Goes In It

Point: Project structure, coding conventions, preferred tools and libraries, what never to modify, how to report results. Instructions, not documentation.

Visual: Real CLAUDE.md file walkthrough: section by section, explaining what each part does for Claude's decision-making in practice

Target words: ~210w

Beat -- What Stays Out

Point: CLAUDE.md is not documentation, not a changelog, not a style guide. Keep it under 200 lines. Include only what Claude needs to make decisions -- everything else is noise.

Visual: Side-by-side: bloated CLAUDE.md (200+ lines of documentation) vs lean CLAUDE.md (30 lines of actual instructions) -- show how Claude performs with each

Target words: ~160w

Beat -- The /init Shortcut

Point: Run /init in your project and Claude Code generates a starter CLAUDE.md based on your folder structure and detected tech stack. Treat it as a starting point -- review and refine it.

Visual: Terminal: type /init, generated CLAUDE.md appears, open it to show what Claude produced, edit to add project-specific rules

Target words: ~130w

Beat -- CTA Bridge

Point: CLAUDE.md is written. Next: Claude Permissions -- how to control what Claude can and cannot do inside your project without watching every command.

Visual: Preview clip from Claude Permissions Explained

Target words: ~60w

ANALOGY BANK

- CLAUDE.md: Like an employee onboarding document -- instead of explaining your project conventions to every new contractor from scratch, you hand them the document on day one. They hit the ground running from session one.

- What to include vs exclude: Like a job brief vs a company handbook -- the brief tells the contractor exactly what they need for this job. The handbook is everything else. Only the brief goes in CLAUDE.md.

THESIS LINE LOCATION

Beat 2 -- The insight is: CLAUDE.md is the difference between Claude guessing your conventions and Claude knowing them -- and most of its bad decisions are guesses, not failures.

FRAMEWORK PHRASE

Persistent project memory

SPECIFICITY BANK

- CLAUDE.md goes in the project root directory
- Claude Code reads it automatically at every session start
- /init command generates a starter CLAUDE.md from project structure
- Recommended max length: under 200 lines
- Multiple CLAUDE.md files supported: root-level (global) and subfolder-level (local context)
- CLAUDE.md content survives context compression (compaction)

CONSTRAINTS

- Do not explain permissions -- that is the next video
- Do not cover the full .claude/ folder -- keep it focused on CLAUDE.md specifically
- Do not write a comprehensive style guide example -- demonstrate with a lean, real example
- Do not explain what LLMs are or how context windows work -- that was earlier in the series

CTA DIRECTION

CLAUDE.md is written. Next: Permissions -- how to control what Claude can and cannot do in your project without being there to approve every command.

PERSONAL ANGLE [DANIEL TO FILL]

Suggested: The specific line you added to CLAUDE.md that immediately stopped Claude from making a mistake it had been making repeatedly -- what was it and what changed?

VULNERABILITY MOMENT [DANIEL TO FILL]

Suggested: A time Claude modified something it should not have touched -- and how adding one line to CLAUDE.md ("never modify X") fixed it permanently.

Note: belongs in Beat 1